

Nick Buttrick
University of Wisconsin-Madison
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Updated 6/01/2026

Academic Positions

2022-Present Assistant Professor, Department of Psychology, University of Wisconsin-Madison

Affiliations:

Center for Community and Nonprofit Studies, University of Wisconsin-Madison

Institute on Aging, University of Wisconsin-Madison

Institute for Diversity Science, University of Wisconsin-Madison

La Follette School of Public Affairs, University of Wisconsin-Madison

Mass Communications Research Center, School of Journalism and Mass Communication, University of Wisconsin-Madison

2020-2022 Postdoctoral Research Associate, School of Public and International Affairs, Princeton University

Education

2016-2020 Ph.D., Social Psychology, University of Virginia

2014-2016 M.A., Social Psychology, University of Virginia

2004-2008 B.A., Cognitive Science, Yale University

Research Support

2024 **PI**, Wisconsin Department of Justice, “Understanding Responsible Firearm Storage” [\$75,000]

2020 **PI**, Summer Institute in Computational Social Science, Follow-up Research Grant [\$7,500].

2020 **PI**, Fetzer Franklin Fund, “Following the Decline Effect” [\$20,000].

2019 **Consultant**, NJ Gun Research Center Internal Funding Grant, “The Lived Experience of Gun Ownership,” Dr. Samantha Heintzelman, P.I. [\$7,500; \$100,000 total].

2018 **Awardee**, University of Virginia Society of Fellows, Summer Fellowship Grant, [\$4,000].

2017 **Awardee**, Society for Personality and Social Psychology, Graduate Travel Award, [\$500].

2016 **Awardee**, National Science Foundation, “A Psychology of Gun Ownership” NSF East Asia and Pacific Summer Institute Grant #1613947 [\$5,400].

Honors, Awards, and Fellowships

2025 Rising Star, Association for Psychological Science

2024	SAGE Early Career Trajectory Award, Society for Personality and Social Psychology
2022	Student Publication Award, Society for Personality and Social Psychology
2020	Invited to the Summer Institute in Computational Social Science
2020	Elected to the Raven honor society, University of Virginia
2019	Invited to the Summer Institute in Social and Personality Psychology, Society for Personality and Social Psychology
2018-2019	National Study of Learning Mindsets Early Career Fellow, Mindset Scholars Network
2018-2019	Elected Senior Junior Fellow, University of Virginia Society of Fellows
2017-2019	Junior Fellow, University of Virginia Society of Fellows

Publications

^ indicates trainee.

1. **Buttrick, N. R.**, Warner, T., Miller, M., & Azrael, D. (in press). What is a gun good for? Esteem and protection in American gun owners. *American Psychologist*
2. Jeong, O.^* & **Buttrick, N. R.*** (2026). American gun ownership and the ingroup/outgroup divide. *PNAS Nexus*, 5(5), pgag145. DOI: 10.1093/pnasnexus/pgag145.
*Authors contributed equally
3. **Buttrick, N. R.** (2026). Safe storage of home firearms: The who, what, and to whom of persuasion. *Policy Insights from Behavioral and Brain Sciences*, 13(1), 44-52. DOI: 10.1177/23727322251404388.
4. Okada, S.^ & **Buttrick, N. R.** (2026). Love him for the enemies he has made: Signaling by inflammatory pro-gun rhetoric. *Political Psychology*, 47(3), e70074. DOI: 10.1111/pops.70074.
5. Rabinowitz, M., Alaoui-Soce, A., **Buttrick, N. R.**, & Tamir, D. (2026). Developing the HeART: Tracking racial heterogeneity in fiction reading habits. *Reading Research Quarterly*, 61(2), e70093. DOI: 10.1002/rrq.70093.
6. Warner, T. D., **Buttrick, N. R.**, Carpenter, S. M., & Kohlbeck, S. (in press). Who (and what) are responsible firearm owners? Correlates of perceived responsible identities and firearm storage practices. *Health Promotion Practice*
7. **Buttrick, N. R.**, Yang, S.^, & Okada, S.^ (2025). Mass shootings durably increase the sale of alcohol in American communities. *PNAS Nexus*, 4(1), pgae570. DOI: 10.1093/pnasnexus/pgae570

8. Oishi, S., Choi, H., Cha, Y., Heintzelman, S. J., **Buttrick, N. R.**, & Westgate, E. C. (2025). Differing worldviews: The politics of happiness, meaning, and psychological richness. *Journal of Personality*, 9(3), 653-669. DOI: 10.1111/jopy.12959
9. **Buttrick, N. R.**, Cha, Y., & Oishi, S. (2024). Shifts in residential mobility predict shifts in culture. *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin*, 52(2), 434-451. DOI: 10.1177/01461672241280998
10. Axt, J. R.*, **Buttrick, N. R.***, & Feng, R. Y. (2024). A comparative investigation of the predictive validity of four implicit association measures of bias and prejudice. *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin*, 50(3), 871-888. DOI: 10.1177/01461672221150229
*Authors contributed equally
11. **Buttrick, N. R.** (2024). Studying large language models as compression algorithms for human culture. *Trends in Cognitive Sciences*, 28(3), 187-189. DOI: 10.1016/j.tics.2024.01.001
12. **Buttrick, N. R.**, Westgate, E. C., & Oishi, S. (2023). Reading literary fiction is associated with a more complex worldview. *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin*, 49(9), 1408-1420. DOI: 10.1177/01461672221106059
13. **Buttrick, N. R.** & Oishi, S (2023). Money and happiness: A consideration of history and psychological mechanisms. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 120(13), e2301893120. DOI: 10.1073/pnas.2301893120
14. Westgate, E., **Buttrick, N. R.**, Lin, Y., El Helou, G., Agostini, M., Belanger, J., Gutzkow, B,... & Leander, N. P. (2023). Pandemic boredom: Little evidence that lockdown-related boredom affected risky public health behaviors across 116 countries. *Emotion*, 23(8), 2370–2384. DOI: 10.1037/emo0001118
15. **Buttrick, N. R.** & Mazen, J. (2022). Historical prevalence of slavery predicts contemporary American gun ownership. *PNAS Nexus* 1(3), pgac117. DOI: 10.1093/pnasnexus/pgac117
16. **Buttrick, N. R.** & Oishi, S. (2022). Socioecology and fiction. *Behavioral and Brain Sciences*, 45 e280. DOI:10.1017/S0140525X21002223
17. Raza, S., Westgate, E. C., **Buttrick, N. R.**, Heintzelman, S., Furrer, R., Gilbert, D. T., Libby, L. K., & Wilson, T. D. (2021). A trade-off model of intentional thinking for pleasure. *Emotion* 22(1), 115-128. DOI: 10.1037/emo0001029
18. **Buttrick, N. R.** & Oishi, S. (2021). The cultural dynamics of declining residential mobility. *American Psychologist*, 76(6), 904-916. DOI: 10.1037/amp0000881

19. Wienk, M., **Buttrick, N. R.**, & Oishi, S. (2021). The psychology of income inequality and redistribution. *European Review of Social Psychology*. DOI: 10.1080/10463283.2021.1955458
20. Burnette, J., Hoyt, C., **Buttrick, N. R.**, & Auster-Gussman, L. (2021). Well-being in the time of COVID-19: Do metaphors and mindsets matter? *International Journal of Psychology*, 51(1), 87-95. DOI: 10.1002/ijop.12785
21. Nisa, C. F., Belanger, J. J., Faller, D. G., **Buttrick, N. R.**, Mireau, J. O., Austin, M.,... & Leander, N. P. (2021). Lives versus Livelihoods? Perceived economic risk has a stronger association with support for COVID-19 preventive measures than perceived health risk. *Scientific Reports*, 11, 9669. DOI: 10.1038/s41598-021-88314-4
22. Westgate, E. C., Wilson, T. D., **Buttrick, N. R.**, Furrer, R., & Gilbert, D. T. (2021). What makes thinking for pleasure pleasurable? *Emotion*, 21(5), 981–989. DOI: 10.1037/emo0000941
23. Ebersole, C. R., Mathur, M. B., Baranski, E., Bart-Plange, D.-J., **Buttrick, N. R.**,...& Nosek, B. A. (2020). Many Labs 5: Testing pre-data-collection peer review as an intervention to increase replicability. *Advances in Methods and Practices in Psychological Science*, 3(3), 309-331. DOI: 10.1177/2515245920958687.
24. **Buttrick, N. R.**, Aczcel, B., Aeschbach, L. F., Bakos, B.,...& Wood, M. (2020). Many Labs 5: Registered Replication Report of Vohs & Schooler (2008), Study 1., *Advances in Methods and Practices in Psychological Science*, 3(3), 429-438. DOI: 10.1177/2515245920917931
25. Piester, H. E., DeRieux, C. M., Tucker, J. **Buttrick, N. R.**, Galloway, J. N., & Wilson, T. D. (2020). “I’ll Try the Veggie Burger”: Increasing purchases of sustainable foods with information about sustainability and taste. *Appetite*, 155(1). DOI: 10.1016/j.appet.2020.104842
26. Oishi, S., Choi, H., Koo, M., Galinha, I., Ishii, K., Komiya, A., Luhmann, M.,...**Buttrick, N. R.**,...& Besser, L. (2020). Happiness, meaning, and psychological richness. *Affective Science*, 1, 107-115. DOI: 10.1007/s42761-020-00011-z
27. **Buttrick, N. R.** (2020). Protective gun ownership as a coping mechanism. *Perspectives on Psychological Science*, 15(4), 835-855. DOI: 10.1177/1745691619898847
28. **Buttrick, N. R.**, Moulder, R., & Oishi, S. (2020). Historical change in the moral foundations of political persuasion. *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin*, 46(11), 1523-1537. DOI: 10.1177/0146167220907467
Society for Personality and Social Psychology Student Paper Award, 2021
29. Axt, J. R., Conway, M. A., Westgate, E. C. & **Buttrick, N. R.** (2020). Implicit transgender attitudes independently predict beliefs about gender and transgender people.

Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 47(2), 257-274. DOI: 10.1177/0146167220921065

30. **Buttrick, N. R.***, Axt, J. R.*, Ebersole, C. R., & Huband, J. (2020). Re-assessing the incremental predictive validity of Implicit Association Tests. *Journal of Experimental Social Psychology*, 88. DOI: 10.1016/j.jesp.2019.103941
*Authors contributed equally
31. Oishi, S., Choi, H., **Buttrick, N. R.**, Heintzelman, S. J., Kushlev, K., Westgate, E. C., Tucker, J.,...& Besser, L. (2019). The Psychologically Rich Life Questionnaire. *Journal of Research in Personality* 81, 257-270. DOI: 10.1016/j.jrp.2019.06.010
32. Wilson, T.D., Westgate, E.C., **Buttrick, N. R.**, & Gilbert, D.T. (2019). The mind in its own place: The difficulties and benefits of thinking for pleasure. *Advances in Experimental Social Psychology*, 60, 175-221. DOI: 10.1016/bs.aesp.2019.05.001
33. Oishi, S., Koo, M., & **Buttrick, N. R.** (2019). The socio-ecological psychology of upward social mobility. *American Psychologist*, 74(7), 751-763. DOI: 10.1037/amp0000422
34. **Buttrick, N. R.**, Choi, H. Wilson, T. D., Oishi, S., ...& Wilks, D. (2019). Cross-cultural consistency and relativity in the enjoyment of thinking versus doing. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*. DOI: 10.1037/pspp0000198
35. Camerer, C. F., Dreber, A., Holtzmeister, F., Ho, T.-H.,...**Buttrick, N. R.**,...& Wu, H. (2018). Evaluating the Replicability of Social Science Experiments in *Nature* and *Science* between 2010 and 2015. *Nature Human Behaviour*, 2, 637-644. DOI: 10.1038/s41562-018-0399-z
36. **Buttrick, N. R.**, Heintzelman, S., & Oishi, S. (2017). Inequality & well-being. *Current Opinion in Psychology*, 18, 15-20. DOI: 10.1016/j.copsyc.2017.07.016
37. Alahmadi, S., **Buttrick, N. R.**, Gilbert, D., Hardin, A., Westgate, E., & Wilson, T. D.* (2017). You can do it if you really try: The effects of motivation on enjoying one's own thoughts. *Motivation & Emotion*, 41(5), 545-561. DOI: 10.1007/s11031-017-9625-7
*Authors in alphabetical order
38. **Buttrick, N.R.** & Oishi, S. (2017). The psychological consequences of income inequality. *Social and Personality Psychology Compass*, 11, e12304. DOI: 10.1111/spc3.12304
39. Wilson, T. D. & **Buttrick, N. R.** (2016). New directions in social psychological interventions to improve academic achievement. *Journal of Educational Psychology*, 108(3), 392-396. DOI: 10.1037/edu0000111

40. Mitkidis, P., Xygalatas, D., **Buttrick, N. R.**, Porubanova, M., & Lienard, P. (2015). The impact of authority on cooperation: A cross-cultural examination of systemic trust. *Adaptive Human Behavior and Physiology*, 1(3), 341-357. DOI: 10.1007/s40750-014-0011-3
41. Catapano, R., **Buttrick, N. R.**, Widness, J., Goldstein, R., & Santos, L. (2014). Capuchin monkeys do not show human-like pricing effects. *Frontiers in Psychology*, 5, 1330. DOI: 10.3389/fpsyg.2014.01330

Manuscripts Under Review & Invited

^ indicates trainee.

Buttrick, N. R., Janke, A.^, & Lesniak, A.^ (invited). Large language models used as cultural search engines reflect stereotypes more than reality. *Journal of Cross-Cultural Psychology*.

Cha., Y., Lu, P. C., Oishi, S. & **Buttrick, N. R.** (invited revision). Post-hoc multiverse analysis: A method for addressing cherry-picking concerns in large-scale secondary dataset research. *Advances in Methods and Practices in Psychological Science*.

Choi, H., Oishi, S., Cha, Y., Westgate, E., Heintzelman, S., **Buttrick, N. R.**, & Seitov, A. (invited revision). The emotional tone of a happy life, a meaningful life, and a psychologically rich life. *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin*.

Choi, S.,^ Jeong, O.,^ Cha, Y., & **Buttrick, N. R.** (invited revision). Historical pathogen threat and social ties: Strengthening bonds, weakening bridges. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*.

Cohen, A. L. & **Buttrick, N. R.** (invited revision). Reading fiction in childhood predicts the ability to imagine our own future. *Psychonomic Bulletin & Review*.

Buttrick, N. R. (under review). Black political power during Reconstruction and White migration from the South during Jim Crow predict contemporary American gun ownership

Buttrick, N. R.*, Heintzelman, S. J.,* Medina-DeVilliers, S.,* & Wang, X. (under review). The world through gun sights: Salient weapons may incompletely help owners deal with psychological threat.

*Authors contributed equally

Buttrick, N. R., Warner, T., Miller, M., & Azrael, D. (under review). What does it mean to be a responsible firearm owner? Definitional variations and differential outcomes.

Hamilton, H. R., **Buttrick, N. R.**, & Oishi, S. (under review). Drinking and the good life: A daily diary study.

Losee, J.* & **Buttrick, N. R.*** (under review). Ethnic status threat in Americans causes a preference for guns over civic action.

*Authors contributed equally

Refereed Presentations and Chaired Symposia

2026

Buttrick, N. R. (2026, February). Ethnic status threat causes preferences for guns over civic action. In Schmiechel, B. J. (Chair). *Gun psychology: Wide-ranging consequences for cognitions, emotions, attitudes, and intentions*. Symposium conducted at the meeting of the Society for Personality and Social Psychology, Chicago, IL.

2025

Buttrick, N. R. (2025, November). Armed sheepdogs: American gun ownership and the ingroup/outgroup divide. Talk presented at the meeting of the National Research Conference for the Prevention of Firearm-Related Harms, Tempe, AZ.

Buttrick, N. R. (2025, October). Armed sheepdogs: American gun ownership and the ingroup/outgroup divide. In X. Brown (Chair). *Guns in America: Firearms attitudes under threat and intergroup conflict*. Symposium conducted at the meeting of the Society of Experimental Social Psychology, Lisbon, Portugal.

2023

Buttrick, N. R. (2023, October). Reading literary fiction is associated with a more complex worldview. In **N. R. Buttrick** (Chair). *Stories to Live By: How Narratives Shape Our Psychological Experience*. Symposium conducted at the meeting of the Society of Experimental Social Psychology, Madison, WI.

Buttrick, N. R. (2023, October). Seeing the world through gun sights. Talk presented at the meeting of the Person Memory Interest Group, Fontana, WI.

Buttrick, N. R. & Whiting, M. (2023, July). Dy/normic webs of belief. Talk presented at the 9th International Conference on Computational Social Science, Copenhagen, Denmark.

Buttrick, N. R. (2023, March). Seeing the world through gun sights. In **N. R. Buttrick** (Chair). *American Protective Gun Culture*. Symposium conducted at the meeting of the American Association for the Advancement of Science, Washington, DC.

2022

Buttrick, N. R. (2022, October). Historical prevalence of slavery predicts contemporary American gun ownership. In **N. R. Buttrick** (Chair). *The Group Dynamics of Contemporary American Firearms Ownership*. Symposium conducted at the meeting of the Society of Experimental Social Psychology, Philadelphia, PA.

Buttrick, N. R. (2022, February). Historical prevalence of slavery predicts contemporary American gun ownership. In A. Allen & G. D. Higginbotham (Chairs). *Acknowledging Racism's Legacy: Re-Centering History in Studying Contemporary Racism*. Symposium conducted at the meeting of the Society of Personality and Social Psychology, San Francisco, CA.

2020

Buttrick, N. R. (2020, February). 'A True Friend with Six Hearts' - Using firearms to cope with psychological threat. In **N. R. Buttrick** (Chair). *New Directions in the Social Psychology of Firearms*. Symposium conducted at the meeting of the Society of Personality and Social Psychology, New Orleans, LA.

2019

Buttrick, N. R. (2019, February). Guns as a coping mechanism. In **N. R. Buttrick** (Chair). *The Social Psychology of Firearms and Firearm Ownership*. Symposium conducted at the meeting of the Society of Personality and Social Psychology, Portland, OR.

Buttrick, N. R. (2019, January). Guns as a coping mechanism. *Student Choice Colloquium*. University of Virginia.

2018

Buttrick, N. R., Heintzelman, S., Weser, V., & Oishi, S. (2018, May). Higher population density and lower meaning in life. In M. Titova (Chair), *The Psychology of Place and Home*. Symposium conducted at the meeting of the Association for Psychological Science, San Francisco, CA.

Invited Presentations

Apr. 2026	Global Psychology Seminar Open Lecture, Yonsei University, Seoul SK
Jan. 2026	Social Area Talk, University of Florida, Gainesville, FL
Apr. 2025	PsyChi Initiation, University of Wisconsin-Madison, Madison, WI
Feb. 2025	Social Area Talk, University of Chicago, Chicago, IL
Feb. 2025	Social Area Brownbag, Northwestern University. Evanston, IL
Feb. 2025	Social Area Talk Series, Texas A&M. College Station, TX
Feb. 2025	Research Lunch Seminar, Management and Human Resources Area, Wisconsin School of Business. Madison, WI
Apr. 2024	Health Care Systems Research Network. Milwaukee, WI
Dec. 2023	Social Area Talk Series, University of Washington. Seattle, WA
Sep. 2023	Association for Psychological Science: Science for Society Series
Sep. 2023	Firearm Injury Prevention Initiative at the University of Colorado. Boulder, CO
Sep. 2019	U.S. District Court, Western District of Virginia. Roanoke, VA
Apr. 2019	Albemarle County Government. Charlottesville, VA
Oct. 2018	University of Virginia Office of Undergraduate Admissions. Charlottesville, VA
Oct. 2018	Chemistry & Engineering News. Washington, DC
Oct. 2017	Suffolk University Law School Fair Housing Conference. Boston, MA

Ad-Hoc Reviewer

National Science Foundation; Israel Science Foundation; American Journal of Criminal Justice; American Journal of Public Health; Asian Journal of Social Psychology; BMC Psychology; British Journal of Social Psychology; British Journal of Sociology; British Journal of Political Science; City & Community; Climatic Change; Developmental Psychology; Empirical Studies of the Arts; European Review of Social Psychology; Journal of Applied Social Psychology; Journal of Educational Psychology; Journal of Experimental Psychology: General; Journal of Experimental Social Psychology; Journal of Gerontology: Social Sciences; Journal of the History of the Behavioral Sciences; Journal of Personality and Social Psychology; Journal of Threat Assessment and Management; Justice Quarterly; Learning & Individual Differences; Nature Communications; Nature Human Behaviour; Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin; PNAS; PNASNexus; Psychological Inquiry; Psychological Science; Social Psychological and Personality Science; Social Science & Medicine, Social Science Research

Teaching

2023-Present *Cultural Psychology* (Psych 501/528), University of Wisconsin-Madison
2023-Present *Advanced Social Psychology* (Psych 729), University of Wisconsin-Madison
2026 *Psychology for Pragmatists* (Psych 711), University of Wisconsin-Madison

Departmental Service

2025-2026 Steering Committee for Data Science in Human Behavior Masters Program, University of Wisconsin-Madison
2024-2026 Participant Pool Committee, University of Wisconsin-Madison
2025-2026 Social Area Open Rank Search Committee, University of Wisconsin-Madison
2024-2025 Social Area Open Rank Search Committee, University of Wisconsin-Madison
2024-2025 Social Area Assistant Professor Search Committee, University of Wisconsin-Madison
2024 Teaching Faculty Search Committee, University of Wisconsin-Madison
2023-2025 New Personnel Committee, University of Wisconsin-Madison
2018-2020 Building Committee, University of Virginia
2016-2020 Participant Pool Coordinator, University of Virginia
2016-2020 Social Area Representative, University of Virginia

Advising

Dissertation Committee

2025 Kat Swerbenski

Preliminary Exam Committee (External Member)

2025 Indri Maulidar (Journalism & Mass Communications)
2025 Alexis Moore (Journalism & Mass Communications)

2022 Aria Duan (Cognitive Psychology)

First Year Project Committee

2025 Ocka Jeong (Chair)

2025 Aditi Hosangadi

2024 Adam Baker

2024 Sue Cha

Selected Press

The New York Times, The Los Angeles Times, Vox, The Trace, The Financial Times, Salon, Scientific American, Nature Reviews Psychology.